

From: Dressage Dressage@equestrian.org.au
Subject: RE: Bitless Dressage Pilot Proposal and Request for Permission to Compete Bitless
Date: 10 March 2026 at 1:02 pm
To: motherofpekes@icloud.com



Dear Paula,

I'm replying about your request below for an exemption to ride bitless; approval cannot be provided for participation in a bitless bridle at EA Dressage competitions even as HC, as it is currently not allowed in the EA Dressage rules.

Thank you,

Kind regards,

Caiwen

Caiwen Cusworth

Sport Development Officer
Equestrian Australia

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From: motherofpekes@icloud.com <motherofpekes@icloud.com>

Sent: Friday, 6 March 2026 4:39 PM

To: Dressage NSW Inc <admin@dressagensw.com.au>; Vireena Peacock <vireena@ensw.org.au>; Dressage <Dressage@equestrian.org.au>; Equestrian Info <info@equestrian.org.au>; NCEC Event Secretary <ncecevents@gmail.com>

Subject: Bitless Dressage Pilot Proposal and Request for Permission to Compete Bitless

Dear Equestrian Australia, Equestrian NSW, and NCEC Dressage,

Further to my previous correspondence regarding the possibility of introducing a pilot project to allow bitless bridles in dressage competition, I would like to provide additional information that may assist in your consideration of this proposal.

I have recently reviewed the national dressage regulations of the KNHS, the

governing body for equestrian sport in the Netherlands. Their national rules specifically allow dressage tests to be ridden in approved bitless bridles up to ZZ-Zwaar level (approximately equivalent to Small Tour preparation).

The relevant sections of the Dutch national dressage regulations for your reference. The full rules can be found here:

<https://www.knhs.nl/reglementen/disciplinereglement-dressuur>

The relevant section is Article 147, which reads:

“Dressage tests may be ridden bitless up to the ZZ-Zwaar level for both horses and ponies. From the Light Tour level onwards, participation bitless is only permitted hors concours (HC).

The following bitless bridles are permitted (see the KNHS Harness Guide):

- The sidepull
- The chin-crossed bitless bridle
- The cheek-crossed bitless bridle
- Other permitted bitless bridles with the reins attached directly to the noseband

The bridle must be made of leather with a noseband at least 2 cm wide. There may be no metal core in the noseband. When using a chin-crossed or cheek-crossed bridle, if cords are used they must have a minimum diameter of 6 mm.

The description of the individual dressage tests and associated explanations contained in Appendix 6 apply, with the exception that in dressage tests ridden bitless, ‘contact’ as described in the training scale means light contact on the reins with the horse and the horse’s head and neck position.”

Of particular interest is the way the Dutch rules define contact when riding bitless. Rather than referring to contact with a bit, the rules define contact as light rein contact with the horse, while judges continue to assess the same qualities of training and performance. In other words, judging remains based on the training scale and the horse’s way of going, rather than the hardware used.

This approach allows bitless participation without altering the fundamental principles of dressage judging, and may therefore provide a useful precedent when considering how bitless riding could be incorporated within existing dressage structures in Australia.

As previously mentioned, I would be very interested in supporting a small pilot project or demonstration class to explore how this might work within the Australian context.

In the meantime, I would also like to respectfully request permission to ride in a bitless bridle at the upcoming NCEC dressage competition for which entries are currently open. I would of course be happy to compete hors concours (HC) if that would make participation easier within the existing rules

would make participation easier within the existing rules.

My intention is simply to demonstrate that a horse trained according to the scales of training can be presented successfully in a bitless bridle while still meeting the same standards expected in dressage competition.

Thank you very much for your time and consideration. I would be grateful for any guidance you may be able to provide.

Kind regards,
Paula Lasersohn